

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

LUCKY 13 FOR THE PM

Who says 13 is an unlucky number? Prime Minister Narendra Modi has launched many an important scheme in his parliamentary constituency Varanasi on that date. He announced Ganga Vilas, the world's longest river cruise—from Varanasi to Dibrugarh—on January 13. A year and a month earlier, on December 13, 2021, the PM inaugurated the Kashi Vishwanath Corridor. All four gates of the corridor combined weigh 13 tonnes and have been prepared in 13-13 sections. Why, Modi was declared BJP's PM candidate on September 13, 2013. After becoming MP from Varanasi in 2014, Suite No. 13 in the Banaras Locomotive Works complex was renovated for his stay.



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Soaring Spirit



What better way to lift aggrieved spirits than fly a kite or two? Makar Sankranti in Gujarat is celebrated as Uttarayan, a kite-flying festival, where the who's who participate. Union home minister **Amit Shah** was in hometown Ahmedabad that weekend as well as in Kalol, Mehsana, where the dissidence of local leaders continues. CM **Bhupendra Patel**, meanwhile, was photographed flying kites with Dariapur MLA Kaushik Jain, in an effort to mollify the Jain community, which is fighting for protection of its religious sites.



SWEET SIGNAL

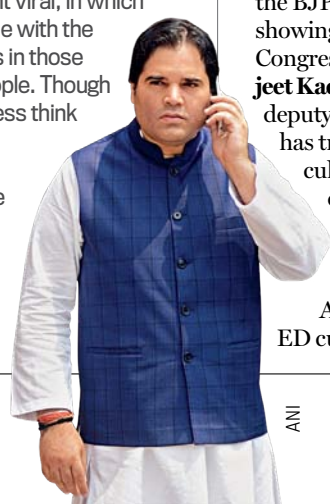




Though West Bengal chief minister **Mamata Banerjee** insists that January 5 is her birthday only on official record and not the actual one, gifts don't stop coming her way on the day. The prime minister sends greetings too. This year, Didi had a surprise gift sender—ex-India captain **Sourav Ganguly**. The gift was date palm jaggery sweets. On January 16, the two also met at Nabanna. Many wondered if this was a prelude to a political innings, especially as Dada was denied a second stint as BCCI chief while Union home minister Amit Shah's son Jai Shah continues as secretary.

Wasted Trip?

Any hope that BJP MP **Varun Gandhi** may join the Congress was firmly laid to rest by cousin Rahul when he said they followed different ideologies. "I can meet him, hug him, but can't accept that ideology," Rahul elaborated. Earlier, there was a buzz that Varun may join the Bharat Jodo Yatra. During its Uttar Pradesh leg, an old speech of Varun's went viral, in which he says he has no issue with the Congress and believes in those who talk of uniting people. Though some in the UP Congress think the party desperately needs a firebrand leader in the state, one Gandhi—Priyanka—is already in charge of the state. So what next for Varun if he leaves the BJP?



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DEFECTION TACTICS

For all the unity of the Bharat Jodo Yatra, the Congress in Maharashtra is a divided house. Rumour (since denied) has it that former minister Amit Deshmukh, son of ex-CM Vilasrao Deshmukh, and his MLA brother Dheeraj may join the BJP. Meanwhile, a video showing former minister and Congress legislator **Vishwajeet Kadam** touching the feet of deputy CM **Devendra Fadnavis** has triggered further speculation. Did Kadam's obeisance indicate a coming shift in loyalty or did it have to do with his father-in-law Avinash Bhosale being in ED custody?

Kaushik Deka with Ashish Misra, Prashant Srivastava, Romita Datta, Jumana Shah and Dhaval Kulkarni